



REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Hawke's Bay

*Where you would work, where you would live,
and what an ordinary week looks like in
Hawke's Bay.*

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Welcome to Hawke's Bay

02 Why Hawke's Bay

03 Hawke's Bay at a glance

04 Healthcare in Hawke's Bay

05 Where clinicians live

06 Cost of living

07 Getting around

08 Food, wine & the everyday

09 Beaches, Te Mata Peak & wine country

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Hawke's Bay

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Matau-a-Māui. Hawke's Bay is a wide, sunlit crescent of coast on the east of the North Island – two cities twenty minutes apart, a fertile plain between them, hill country behind, and one of the great food and wine regions of the southern hemisphere.

The sunny east coast

Hawke's Bay is shaped like a fish hook, which is what its Māori name describes. Napier sits on the northern arm of the bay, rebuilt in Art Deco after the 1931 earthquake and now holding one of the finest concentrations of that architecture anywhere in the world. Hastings lies twenty minutes inland across the Heretaunga plains, larger in its district, and home to the region's base hospital.

Between and around them: apple and pear orchards, some of New Zealand's most celebrated vineyards, and the flat, cyclable Heretaunga plain. Beyond, the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges rise inland, the coast runs south past Te Mata Peak to Cape Kidnappers, and north the road climbs towards Wairoa and the East Cape.

What the region buys you is a good life on a clinical salary: sunshine, beaches, remarkable food and wine, a base hospital, and housing that costs meaningfully less than the Bay of Plenty for a similar lifestyle. What it asks of you is a tolerance for distance from a tertiary centre, and an understanding that this is a region still recovering from a serious natural disaster.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest – but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Hawke's Bay is one of the easiest regions to recommend and one we're careful about, because the lifestyle sells itself and the harder facts – deprivation, distance, the cyclone recovery – need saying out loud.

Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The region, in nine numbers

~180,000

People across the region, from Wairoa in the north to Central Hawke's Bay in the south.

~67,000 / ~55,000

Napier and Hastings — twin cities twenty minutes apart, each with its own character and its own loyalties.

2,200+ hrs

Of sunshine a year. Hawke's Bay competes with Nelson and the Bay of Plenty for sunniest region in the country most years.

1 base hospital

In Hastings, not Napier — a useful thing to know before you choose a suburb. Run by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora.

~4 hrs

To Wellington, where the region's tertiary work is referred. Palmerston North is around two and a half.

~20 min

Between the two cities, and from most addresses to a beach. The plain is flat and the distances are short.

~25%

Of Hawke's Bay people identify as Māori — this is the heartland of Ngāti Kahungunu, the country's third-largest iwi.

Feb 2023

Cyclone Gabrielle. The region is well into recovery, but it reshaped valleys, communities and the clinical picture, and it is part of the honest account.

1 great ride

Around 200km of flat, linked cycle trail across the plains and along the coast — one of the best urban cycling networks in New Zealand.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The hospital is in Hastings

Napier is the better-known city, but the base hospital sits on the Hastings side of the plain. If you work there and live in Napier, that's a twenty-minute commute each way — fine, but worth deciding deliberately.

Napier and Hastings are genuinely different

Napier is coastal, Art Deco, tourism-facing and a little polished. Hastings is inland, larger in its district, more working and more diverse. Locals have firm views. Both are good places to live.

It gets properly hot, and properly dry

Thirty degrees and more in summer, and the region has real drought years. This is the closest the North Island gets to a Mediterranean climate, which is exactly why the wine is so good.

Gabrielle is still present

Two and a half years on, most of the region is fully functioning, but some valleys and communities are still rebuilding, and it comes up in conversation. [The region at a glance](#) covers it honestly.

The food is a real reason to come

Not marketing. Gimblett Gravels reds, exceptional chardonnay, orchards in every direction and one of the best farmers' markets in the country. It changes how you eat.

The seasonal workforce shapes the year

Horticulture brings thousands of seasonal workers, many from the Pacific, into the region each harvest. It affects the population, the economy and the clinical caseload.

A note on names

Te Matau-a-Māui – the fish hook of Māui – is the bay's name in te reo Māori, and the shape of the coastline is the hook. Heretaunga is the plain around Hastings. This is the rohe of Ngāti Kahungunu, whose presence in the health system and the community here is substantial.

You're not expected to arrive fluent. You are expected to try. [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation and the words you'll hear on the ward.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Hawke's Bay specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally – visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools – lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Hawke's Bay](#) for the full case – and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Where clinicians live](#), because the Napier-or-Hastings question is the first real decision you'll make here.

Why Hawke's Bay

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Hawke's Bay makes one of the strongest overall cases in this collection, and it is the region we find ourselves comparing most often to the Bay of Plenty. On most measures that a clinician actually feels, it wins.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, radiographer, physiotherapist or sonographer on a given step earns the same in Hastings as in Auckland or Tauranga. What changes is what the money buys.

Here it buys a good deal. Housing costs meaningfully less than in Tauranga or Auckland for a comparable coastal, sunny lifestyle — not as little as Palmerston North or Southland, but enough that buying a family home on a clinical salary is realistic rather than aspirational. Commutes are twenty minutes. Parking is easy. The food and wine are extraordinary and, being local, are cheaper than they should be.

The offsets are real: this is four hours from Wellington and two and a half from Palmerston North, so tertiary care and some services mean travelling. Parts of the region carry significant deprivation. And the region is still finishing a recovery from a major cyclone. None of those things should stop you — but you should know them.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Ten to twenty-five minutes to the hospital depending which city you live in. Flat roads, easy parking, and a genuine option to cycle year-round.

After work

Long light evenings for most of the year. Marine Parade in Napier, Te Mata Peak for the view, or a swim. The sea is comfortable from December to April.

Saturday

The Hastings farmers' market, then a cellar door or a beach. This is the region's great weekend rhythm, and it does not get old.

Sunday

A stretch of the cycle trails, the gannet colony at Cape Kidnappers, Waimarama or Ocean Beach, or the hill country inland.

A long weekend

Taupō and the volcanoes two and a quarter hours west, Gisborne three north, the Wairarapa and Wellington to the south.

Summer

Hot, dry and busy. The region fills for the Art Deco Festival, the wine events and the beaches. It is the best of it, and the emergency department feels it.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough clinical work?

Napier or Hastings?

How is the region after Cyclone Gabrielle?

Is it a good place with children?

Is it international enough?

What is the weather really like?

Where we'd point you instead

Your specialty needs tertiary volume

Neurosurgery, cardiothoracics and the most complex work go to Wellington, four hours away. If you need those volumes, you need a tertiary centre.

You want a big city

Napier and Hastings together make a substantial region but not a metropolis. Major touring acts, big galleries and a dense cultural calendar mean travelling.

You need frequent international flights

Napier has good domestic connections but long-haul means Auckland or Wellington first. It is a longer travel day than from a main centre.

The deprivation would weigh on you

Parts of this region carry significant deprivation and unmet need, and the clinical work reflects that. Many people come here specifically for it. Others find it heavy, and that is fair to know.

You'd worry about extreme weather

This is an east coast region with drought risk and exposure to ex-tropical cyclones. Gabrielle was exceptional, but it was not imaginary.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the same warmth and coast with a bigger city around it? **Bay of Plenty** – though read its cost chapter first.

Want the best housing value in the North Island? **Palmerston North**, two and a half hours south-west.

Want a tertiary hospital and affordable housing? **Waikato**.

Want rural practice with real autonomy and the strongest Māori health work in the country? **Gisborne**, four hours north.

In our experience

Hawke's Bay suits clinicians who want the good-life move to still feel professional — a proper base hospital, then vineyards and coastline for everything after five. It's the region we hear the fewest regrets about.

Hawke's Bay at a glance

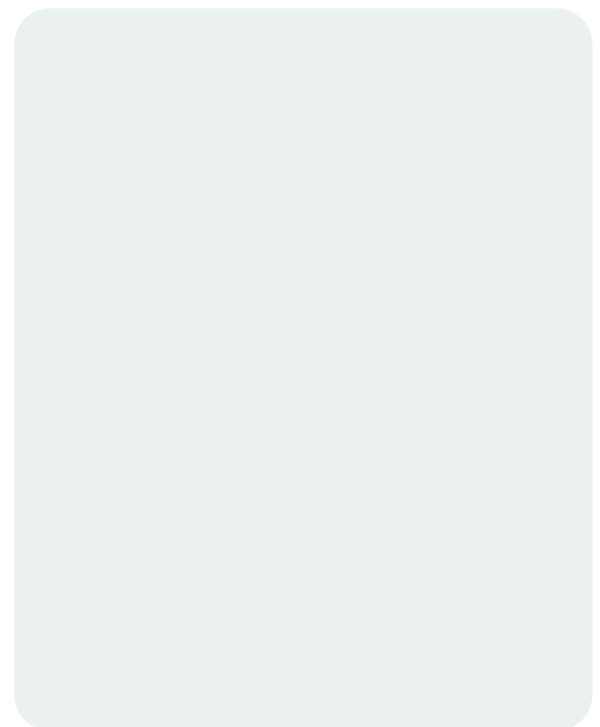
Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

A wide bay open to the Pacific, a fertile alluvial plain behind it, and ranges beyond that which strip the westerly of its rain. That geography gives Hawke's Bay its sunshine, its wine and its drought — and, occasionally, its floods.

The shape of the region

Napier sits at the northern end of the bay on a low hill that was an island until the 1931 earthquake lifted the seabed around it. South across the flat **Heretaunga plain** lies Hastings, with Havelock North tucked beneath Te Mata Peak between them. The plain is the productive heart: orchards, vineyards and market gardens on some of the best soil in the country.

West, the land rises through hill-country sheep and cattle stations to the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges — the barrier that makes this coast dry. North, the road climbs past the Esk Valley towards Wairoa and eventually the East Cape. South, the coast runs past Cape Kidnappers and its gannet colony into Central Hawke's Bay, the small towns of Waipawa and Waipukurau, and eventually the Wairarapa.



Where Napier sits, with the straight-line distance to Hastings and Gisborne

The four seasons

Summer
Dec – Feb
24–30°C

Hot and dry

Autumn

Mar – May

18–24°C

Harvest, and the best of it

Winter

Jun – Aug

13–16°C

Mild coast, frosty inland

Spring

Sep – Nov

16–22°C

Blossom, then warm

Indicative daytime highs on the plain. Inland and in the hill country, winters are colder and frosts are routine.

What the numbers don't tell you

This is the closest the North Island comes to a Mediterranean climate. Somewhere above 2,200 sunshine hours a year, hot dry summers, and mild winters on the coast. It is why the wine ripens the way it does, and why the fruit is what it is. If you have come from northern Europe, the number of usable outdoor days here will genuinely change your year.

Drought is a real feature, not a rare event. The ranges take the rain and the plain can go a long time without it. Water restrictions in summer are normal, and dry years are hard on the rural economy in a way that reaches into the clinic.

The east coast is exposed to weather from the tropics. Ex-tropical systems track down onto this coast, and when they arrive they can bring extraordinary amounts of rain in a short time onto steep hill country. That is the mechanism behind the region's flood history.

Houses need cooling as much as heating. Unusual for New Zealand. Summer heat on the plain is significant, so shade, insulation and a heat pump that works both ways all matter. Still check the Healthy Homes compliance statement, which is a legal requirement and covered in the national [Renting in New Zealand](#) chapter.

Cyclone Gabrielle, honestly

In February 2023 Cyclone Gabrielle brought catastrophic rain to Hawke's Bay. Rivers broke their banks, valleys flooded, roads and bridges were destroyed, thousands of people were displaced and lives were lost. It was the most damaging weather event in the region's modern history.

Where things stand now: Napier and Hastings functioned throughout and are fully operating. Recovery in the worst-hit areas — the Esk and Tūtaekurī valleys, parts of the Ngāruroro catchment, and the road north to Wairoa — has been long, and some of it continues. Significant work on stopbanks, roads and land-use planning is under way.

Why it matters clinically: it left a lasting imprint on rural mental health, on how services plan for isolation and access, and on the region's whole conversation about resilience. Colleagues here lived through it. It is worth arriving informed rather than asking about it as trivia.

Where things are, in driving time

Napier ↔ Hastings

20 minutes across the plain. The single most-driven route in the region.

→ Havelock North

10 minutes from Hastings, 25 from Napier, at the foot of Te Mata Peak.

→ The beaches

20 to 40 minutes to Waimarama, Ocean Beach or Waipatiki.

→ Waipukurau / Central Hawke's Bay

45 minutes south. Small towns, real value, rural services.

→ Wairoa

1 hr 30 north. A smaller, strongly Māori community with its own rural health service.

→ Taupō / Palmerston North / Wellington

2 hr 15, 2 hr 30 and about 4 hr respectively. Wellington is the tertiary referral centre.

Words you'll hear

Te Matau-a-Māui Hawke's Bay — the fish hook of Māui, which is the shape of the coast.

Heretaunga The plain around Hastings. Also used for the district.

The Bay What locals call the whole region.

Te Mata Te Mata Peak, above Havelock North. The view, and the after-work walk.

Gimblett Gravels A defined stony sub-region near Hastings that grows the region's best reds.

The Taupō road State Highway 5 over the ranges. Winding, scenic, and to be respected in winter.

RSE workers Seasonal horticultural workers, many from the Pacific, who arrive for harvest.

Art Deco Napier's architecture, rebuilt after 1931, and the February festival around it.

The short version

A sunny, dry, fertile east-coast region with two cities twenty minutes apart and hill country behind. The climate is the reason people come; drought and exposure to tropical weather are the honest costs. The first real decision is Napier or Hastings — **Where clinicians live** is next.

Healthcare in Hawke's Bay

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Hawke's Bay is a base hospital region with a genuinely wide catchment, a substantial equity agenda, and a rural reach that runs from the East Cape road to the Wairarapa border. For most professions it offers real breadth without demanding that you live somewhere remote.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. The base hospital sits in **Hastings** — a point worth absorbing early, because Napier is the better-known city and the two are twenty minutes apart. It carries acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, oncology day services, imaging and a broad outpatient and day-procedure programme for the whole region.

Around it: community and outpatient services across both cities, primary care, iwi and Māori health providers, aged residential care, and rural services reaching north to Wairoa and south into Central Hawke's Bay. Distance is a live factor in the rural districts, and it became a much more prominent one after Cyclone Gabrielle.

Complex and highly specialised work — neurosurgery, cardiothoracic surgery, the most complex paediatrics — is referred to Wellington, about four hours away, with Palmerston North closer for some services.

THE CATCHMENT, NORTH TO SOUTH

One base hospital, and a region that runs from the East Cape road to the Wairarapa border. Worth absorbing early: the hospital is in Hastings, not the better-known city twenty minutes away.

Down the region

Acute medicine and surgery, emergency, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, oncology day services and imaging all sit at the base hospital – with outreach and community services reaching to both ends of this line.

Wairoa · the rural north

Napier

Hastings · the base hospital

Central Hawke's Bay

And out of the region

Neurosurgery, cardiothoracic surgery and the most complex paediatrics go south – Wellington about four hours away, with Palmerston North closer for some services.

Hastings

Wellington · ~4 hours

Napier and Hastings are twenty minutes apart, so either city is a realistic base – but distance is a live factor in the rural districts, and became a much more prominent one after Cyclone Gabrielle.

What the work is like

Real breadth

A base hospital with no competing centre nearby means you see what the region produces. Wide scope, more decisions carried by you, and referral options further away.

Equity at the centre

Around a quarter of Hawke's Bay people identify as Māori, and parts of the region carry significant deprivation and unmet need. Much of the most meaningful work here is in closing that gap.

A large rural catchment

Wairoa to the north and Central Hawke's Bay to the south. Outreach, travel and access work are part of many roles.

A seasonal workforce

Horticulture brings thousands of seasonal workers, many from the Pacific, into the region for harvest. Occupational health, primary care demand and interpreting needs all shift with the season.

Post-cyclone resilience work

Gabrielle changed how services plan for isolation, access and rural mental health. That work is ongoing and, for the right clinician, genuinely purposeful.

Pressure, honestly

A regional base hospital with a wide catchment and real deprivation is a busy hospital. Waiting lists and workforce gaps are as real here as anywhere.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the heartland of Ngāti Kahungunu, the third-largest iwi in the country, and te ao Māori is woven through health delivery here rather than added to it. Iwi and Māori health providers are a substantial part of the care landscape, particularly in Wairoa, Flaxmere and the rural districts.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau in the room and involved in decisions, and services designed around that. You are not expected to arrive fluent — you are expected to try. The national chapter **Te ao Māori at work** covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

What to ask at interview

Which site, and is there any cross-city or rural outreach working? It shapes where you should live.

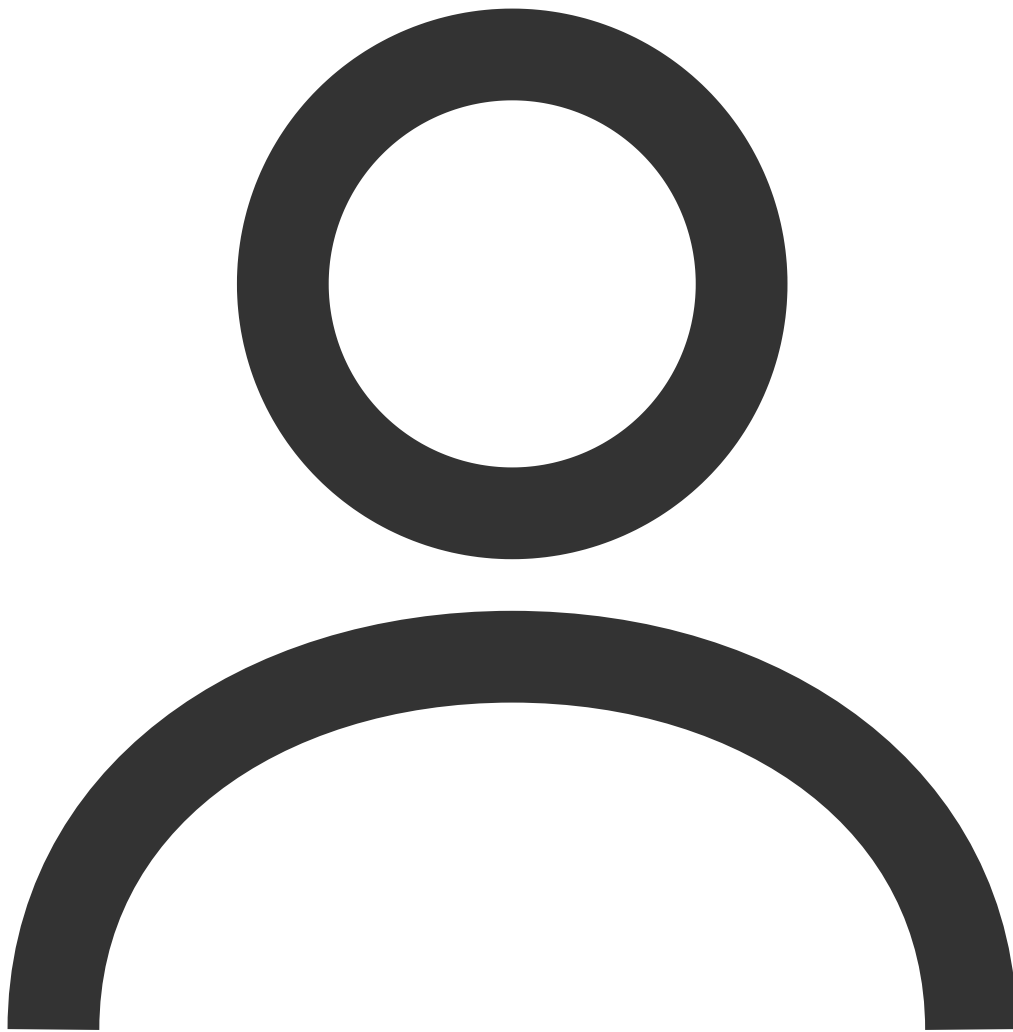
What is the on-call or rostered-hours pattern, and how is it paid under the relevant collective agreement?

What gets referred to Wellington or Palmerston North in my specialty, and how much of that pathway do I stay involved in?

What orientation, supervision and cultural induction is there for clinicians new to New Zealand?

How does the service handle the seasonal harvest peak and the summer visitor influx?

What does professional development funding look like, and is there relocation support?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Hawke's Bay is the region I find hardest to argue against. A base hospital, real equity work, two cities twenty minutes apart, and some of the best food and wine in the southern hemisphere – at less than the Bay of Plenty costs. The people I place here tend to stay.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured – ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system – lives in [How the health system works](#).

Ethicare

Live roles & professions



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by region.

National guide



How national collective agreements work, and what to check before you sign.

Where clinicians live

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 5 of 9

The first real decision in Hawke's Bay is which city. The base hospital is in Hastings, the best-known coastline is in Napier, and they are twenty minutes apart – so plenty of people work in one and live in the other quite happily.

FIRST DECIDE WHICH CITY

Twenty minutes separate them, so plenty of households work in one and sleep in the other. The columns trade different mornings.

Base yourself in Napier

The sea in daily life

The hill, the parade and the marina quarter – the coastal end of the plain.

Character stock

Hillside villas and the Deco streets rebuilt after 1931.

The trade

You commute the plain each morning – an easy, flat twenty minutes, but a commute all the same.

Base yourself in Hastings or Havelock North

Work on the doorstep

The hospital sits on this side – some streets put it inside ten minutes.

The schooling draw

Havelock North's reputation pulls families across the region.

The trade

The coastline people picture when they picture Hawke's Bay is the drive rather than the doorstep.

A common pattern: rent in Napier for the first six months for the sea, then buy on the Hastings side for the school run. Both work.

Napier

Napier Hill & Bluff Hill

The old town on the hill that was once an island, with character houses, views over the bay and steep streets. Sought-after and priced accordingly.

Ahuriri

The redeveloped waterfront and marina quarter – apartments, restaurants and a real sense of place. Popular with couples and downsizers.

Taradale & Greenmeadows

Established, leafy, family-focused suburbs on the Napier side of the plain, with good schools and a shorter run to the Hastings hospital than central Napier.

Marewa

The Art Deco residential suburb, rebuilt after 1931. Charming streets, well located, and increasingly appreciated.

Tamatea & Onekawa

Solid, good-value family suburbs. Where a lot of first homes are bought in Napier.

Te Awanga & Haumoana

Small coastal settlements south of Napier towards Cape Kidnappers – beach, vineyards and a village pace, twenty-five minutes from the hospital.

Hastings & Havelock North

Havelock North

A village at the foot of Te Mata Peak with the best schooling reputation in the region, good cafés and a lovely feel. The premium address, and worth it to many families. Ten minutes to the hospital.

Hastings central & Mahora

Close to the hospital, walkable, with a mix of character housing and newer infill. The shortest commute available anywhere in the region.

St Leonards & Akina

Established family suburbs either side of the centre, well served by schools and parks, and better value than the Napier equivalents.

Frimley & Raureka

Leafy, settled, straightforward. Frimley Park is one of the region's nicest, and prices are sensible.

Flaxmere

The most affordable housing in the urban area, and a community with real strength and real challenges. Significant regeneration under way, and a lot of the region's most important health work happens here.

Clive & the plain

Small settlements and lifestyle blocks between the two cities. Space, land and short drives in both directions.

Further out

Waipawa & Waipukurau

Central Hawke's Bay, 45 minutes south. Country towns with real value, their own schools and a rural health service. A genuine option, not a fallback.

Wairoa

An hour and a half north, on the road to the East Cape. Small, strongly Māori, with its own rural health service – and one of the places Gabrielle hit hardest. Its own decision, not a commute.

Three things to check before you sign

Which city, against which work site. The hospital is in Hastings. Twenty minutes each way is a fine commute, but decide it deliberately rather than discovering it.

Flood exposure and insurance. Post-Gabrielle this is a live question in some areas. Ask directly about the property's history, its flood zoning and its insurability – a reputable agent will answer straight.

The school zone, at the exact address. Havelock North and Taradale schools in particular are zoned and in demand – see [Schools & education](#).

Most clinicians we move here rent for six to twelve months first, which is the right call: it lets you learn which city you actually belong in before committing. How renting works – the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

Cost of living

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 7 of 9

Hawke's Bay sits in the useful middle of this collection. It is not the cheapest region — Palmerston North and Southland are — but it delivers a warm, coastal, food-and-wine lifestyle for materially less than the Bay of Plenty asks for something comparable.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Hawke's Bay against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Where it sits

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Auckland or Tauranga, into a market that costs noticeably less than either. Prices here rose substantially over the last decade, as they did everywhere, and the region is no longer the bargain it once was — but the gap to Tauranga is real and it is the comparison worth making.

Concretely: a family home with a garden in a good school zone, within twenty-five minutes of the hospital, is a realistic purchase on a clinical salary here. In Tauranga the same thing is hard on two incomes. That is the case for Hawke's Bay in one sentence.

Within the region there is a clear ladder. Havelock North and the Napier hills are the premium. Taradale, Marewa and the settled Hastings suburbs are the middle. Flaxmere, Camberley and the outer suburbs are the most affordable urban options, and Central Hawke's Bay is cheaper again.

Renting, by area

Havelock North

The region's premium address, on schooling reputation and village feel. Expect to pay the top of the local range and to compete for anything good.

Napier Hill, Bluff Hill & Ahuriri

Character, views and waterfront. Priced for it, and limited stock.

Taradale, Greenmeadows & Marewa

The sensible middle. Good schools, established streets, reasonable prices and a short run to Hastings.

Hastings suburbs

St Leonards, Akina, Frimley and Mahora offer better value than the Napier equivalents, with the shortest commute in the region.

Flaxmere & the outer suburbs

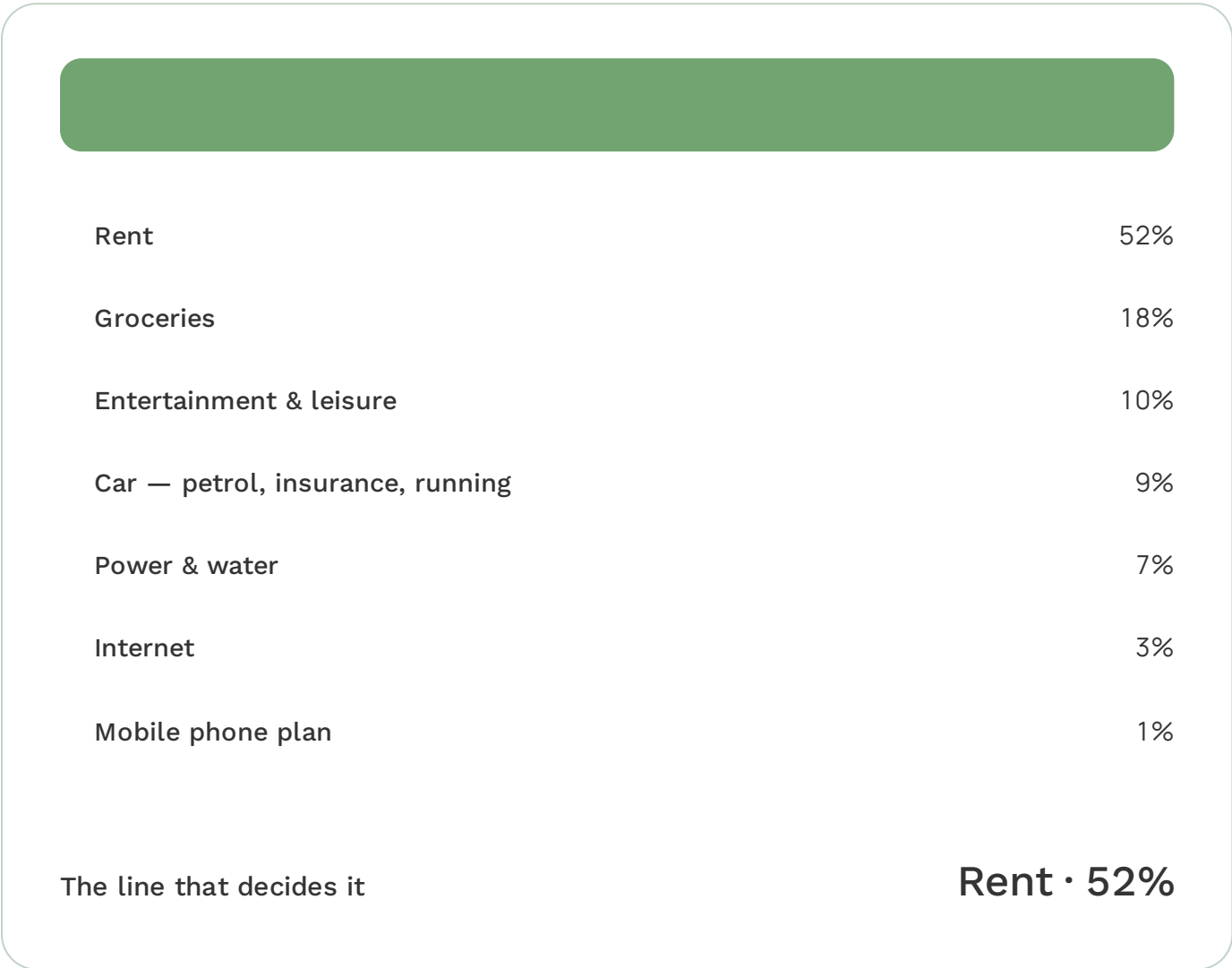
The most affordable urban housing in the Bay by a clear margin.

Central Hawke's Bay

Waipawa and Waipukurau, 45 minutes south. Country-town prices for a proper house and section.

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is just over half the month – more than Palmerston North, materially less than the Bay of Plenty.



Power is among the lowest lines of any region in this collection – a warm, dry climate showing up in a bill rather than a brochure. The car is the trade for it.

Indicative prices that change over time. Note the wine line – living where it is made is one of the few genuine grocery savings in this collection.

The costs particular to here

Insurance, post-Gabrielle

The one genuinely new cost. Flood risk is now priced more carefully in parts of the region, so check a property’s zoning and insurability before you commit – especially in the river valleys.

Summer cooling

Unusual for New Zealand: it gets hot enough here that shade and a heat pump that cools matter as much as one that heats.

Water restrictions

Normal in dry summers. Not a cost so much as an adjustment, particularly if you plan a garden.

Two cities, one car park

If you live in one city and work in the other, that's a twenty-minute commute twice a day.

Cheap, but it's fuel you weren't planning on.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities

Numbeo · cost of living



Napier prices for rent, groceries, transport and dining, against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Napier-New-Zealand>)

Plan your budget

Sorted budget planner



New Zealand's free, government-backed budgeting tool.

(<https://sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner/>)

Official data



The Household Living-Costs Price Index, updated quarterly.

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz/topics/household-living-costs-price-indexes/>)

Property



Compare Napier, Hastings, Havelock North and Central Hawke's Bay side by side.

(<https://www.realestate.co.nz/residential/sale/hawkes-bay>)

Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official rents



Bond-lodgement data by area – the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>)

How pay, tax, IRD numbers, KiwiSaver and sending money home actually work is national and explained once in **Money, tax & banking**.

The honest summary

Not the cheapest region in this collection, but arguably the best value for the lifestyle – a warm, coastal, food-and-wine life for meaningfully less than Tauranga. The one new thing to do your homework on is flood zoning and insurance in the river valleys. Otherwise the numbers here work.

Getting around

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

The Heretaunga plain is flat, the two cities are twenty minutes apart, and there is almost no congestion worth the name. Getting around inside Hawke's Bay is easy. Getting to Wellington is the part to think about.

The twin-city commute

Napier to Hastings is about twenty minutes on the expressway across the plain, and that single route is the spine of the region. Plenty of clinicians live in one city and work in the other; plenty more live in Havelock North or Taradale, which sit between them and shorten it either way.

There is mild thickening at the school run and at either end of the day, and roadworks on the expressway from time to time. That is the whole traffic story. Parking at the hospital and in both city centres is straightforward and cheap or free.

Cycling — one of the best in the country

The **Hawke's Bay Trails** are a Great Ride: roughly two hundred kilometres of linked, sealed, almost entirely flat path across the plain, along the rivers and around the coast. Unusually for a New Zealand network, they connect real places rather than just scenic loops — you can commute, shop and get to a cellar door on them.

Combined with the climate, that makes this one of the few New Zealand regions where cycling to work year-round is comfortable. A good number of clinicians here do exactly that, and it is a strong argument for living in Taradale, Havelock North or central Hastings.

Buses

The regional network

goBay services link Napier, Hastings, Havelock North and Taradale, with school and city routes. Cheap and useful on the main corridors.

Its limits

Frequency outside the main routes is modest and evening service is thin. It will not cover a clinical roster.

Do you need a car?

Yes, though possibly only one per household if you cycle. The region assumes a vehicle for the beaches, the hill country and the rural districts.

No passenger rail

The line carries freight only. Nothing to plan around.

The roads out

The Taupō road (SH5)

West over the ranges, two and a quarter hours to Taupō. Winding, scenic and genuinely to be respected in winter fog and ice.

South to Wellington (SH2)

About four hours via the Manawatū or the Wairarapa. Palmerston North is around two and a half.

North to Gisborne

Around three hours via Wairoa. This is the stretch Gabrielle damaged most severely, and it is worth checking conditions.

Winter and weather

Frost and fog inland, and this is an east-coast region exposed to tropical systems. Check the route before long drives in bad weather.

Flying

Napier Airport

Ten minutes from central Napier, with regular flights to Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch.

Long-haul

Via Auckland or Wellington. Practically speaking, Auckland is your international airport.

Getting home

Budget a comfortable half-day at each end – broadly comparable with most New Zealand regions outside the main centres.

Domestic weekends

Being on the east coast means Taupō, the volcanoes, Gisborne and the Wairarapa are all easy drives.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Napier ↔ Hastings	20 min
Napier → Havelock North	25 min
Hastings → Havelock North	10 min
Napier → airport	10 min
Hastings → Waimarama or Ocean Beach	30–40 min
Hastings → Waipukurau	45 min
Napier → Wairoa	1 hr 30
Napier → Taupō	2 hr 15
Hastings → Palmerston North	2 hr 30
Napier → Gisborne	3 hr
Hastings → Wellington	~4 hr

Times on a good run. Add for the Taupō road in winter and for the northern route in poor weather.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).

Food, wine & the everyday

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 8 of 9



If you care about food, this is the chapter that will decide it. Hawke's Bay has the strongest food and wine culture of any region in this collection, and it is not a tourism claim — it is the everyday consequence of hot summers, good soil and a hundred and fifty years of growing things.

The wine

Hawke's Bay is New Zealand's oldest wine region and, for reds, its best. The **Gimblett Gravels** — a defined stretch of old riverbed near Hastings — produce syrah and Bordeaux-style blends that stand comparison with anywhere. The region's chardonnay is widely held to be the country's finest.

What matters day to day is that the cellar doors are twenty minutes from your house, most of them are free or nearly so to visit, and the wine costs less here than in a Wellington shop. Sunday lunch at a vineyard stops being an occasion and becomes a habit.

The food

This is the fruit bowl of New Zealand: apples, pears, stone fruit, berries and squash off the Heretaunga plain, sold at orchard gates and roadside stalls through the season. Olive oil, cheese, cider and honey are all made locally and well.

The **Hastings farmers' market** on a Sunday morning is, by fairly broad agreement, the best in the country — producers rather than resellers, and half the region there. Napier has its own on Saturdays. Between the two you can eat almost entirely from within thirty kilometres, and eat extremely well.

Eating out

Havelock North

The best concentration in the region — village cafés, bakeries and a couple of genuinely serious restaurants, with Te Mata Peak behind.

Ahuriri & Napier

The waterfront and the Art Deco streets. Good restaurants, wine bars and a strong café scene, busier in summer.

Hastings

More mixed and more everyday, with excellent Asian and Pacific food reflecting the city's population, and a redeveloping centre.

The cellar doors

Several of the region's best restaurants are attached to wineries. Booking is sensible at weekends and essential in February.

Groceries and the practical stuff

All the main supermarket chains, in both cities, plus large-format retail. Food in New Zealand is expensive by British or Australian standards – national rather than regional – but the fresh produce here is the exception, and it is a real one.

For specialist ingredients: there are Asian, Indian and Pacific grocers across both cities, a good range of halal options, and specialist butchers and delis. It is not Auckland. If a

particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, check before committing – the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.

Six Sisters – Napier's heritage street front, and the coffee that comes with it

The rhythm of the year

Harvest is the season that matters

February to April. The region fills with pickers, the wineries work around the clock, and the whole place smells of fruit. It is the best time to be here.

The Art Deco Festival

Napier in February – vintage cars, period dress, and a charming few days. The city books out. Everything happens outdoors

The climate means barbecues, beaches, sport and long evenings for most of the year. Social life is informal and easy to join.

Sport is the social glue

Rugby, netball, cricket, cycling clubs and surf lifesaving. Joining one is the fastest route to knowing people properly.

Honest limitations

Retail is good for the size but not deep. Big shopping trips mean Wellington, Auckland or online.

Touring music, theatre and major exhibitions mostly stop at Wellington or Auckland. The Napier Municipal Theatre and the region's festivals fill some of the gap.

Very specific imported groceries can need ordering in. Most people build up an Auckland order a few times a year.

Beaches, Te Mata Peak & wine country

Hawke's Bay Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

A flat plain with two hundred kilometres of cycle trail on it, a peak with the region's best view above it, surf beaches half an hour east, and hill country and ranges behind. Most of it is free and almost all of it is close.

Te Mata Peak

The landmark, and the region's daily ritual. A steep ridge rising straight off the plain behind Havelock North, with a road to the top and a network of tracks up it. From the summit you get the whole bay, the plain, the ranges and, on a clear day, Ruapehu.

It takes about forty minutes to walk up and it is busy at dawn and dusk with people doing exactly that before or after work. Te Mata is also a place of significance in local tradition, and the story of the sleeping giant is worth knowing before you climb it.

The coast

Waimarama & Ocean Beach

Thirty to forty minutes south-east over the hills. Proper surf beaches, patrolled in summer, and the region's weekend default.

Te Awanga & Haumoana

Twenty-five minutes from Napier, where the vineyards meet the shingle beach. Cellar doors and sea in the same afternoon.

Cape Kidnappers

One of the world's most accessible mainland gannet colonies, on the cliffs at the end of the bay. Reachable on foot at low tide or by tour.

Waipatiki & the northern beaches

North of Napier — small, bush-backed bays that stay quiet even in January.

Marine Parade, Napier

The Norfolk pines, the sunken gardens and the aquarium. A shingle beach rather than a swimming one, and a lovely evening walk.

Fishing and diving

Good off this coast, with crayfish and pāua on the rocky sections. Rules on size and quantity are real – check before you gather.

THE FLAT PLAIN, PUT TO WORK

200 km

OF LINKED, SEALED, FLAT CYCLE TRAIL

Flat, sealed and linked, the network runs along the rivers, around the coast and between the cellar doors. It earns its Great Ride status by being useful: the same paths carry a family Sunday, a wine loop and a commute.

The rides themselves are below – the Wineries loop is the one to do first.

On two wheels

The **Hawke's Bay Trails** deserve their own paragraph. Around two hundred kilometres of linked, sealed, flat path across the plain, along the Tukituki and Ngāruoro rivers and around the coast – one of New Zealand's Great Rides, and unusually useful because it connects real destinations.

The Wineries Ride is the one people do first: a flat loop between cellar doors with a designated driver or a shuttle at the end. The Landscapes and Water Rides cover the coast and the rivers. Bike hire is easy and the whole network is genuinely family-friendly.

Inland and upward

The Tukituki valley

Between Havelock North and the ranges – river swimming holes, vineyards and the prettiest driving in the region.

Kaweka & Ruahine Forest Parks

Serious tramping country an hour or so inland, with huts, tops and real remoteness.

Boundary Stream & Maungaharuru

A mainland island sanctuary north-west of Napier, with some of the best native birdsong in the North Island.

Central Hawke's Bay

South through Waipawa and Waipukurau to the Tukituki's upper reaches and the quiet coast at Porangahau.

Taupō & the volcanoes – 2 hr 15

Over the ranges to the lake, the Tongariro crossing and the ski fields.

Gisborne & the East Cape – 3 hr

North through Wairoa to the first place in the world to see the sun.

Useful links

Tourism

Hawke's Bay NZ



The region's official visitor site: the trails, the cellar doors, events and what's on.

(<https://www.hawkesbaynz.com/>)

Council



Local services, libraries, pools and parks on the Napier side.

(<https://www.napier.govt.nz/>)

Council



Services, schools information and community life around the hospital.

(<https://www.hastingsdc.govt.nz/>)

Outdoors



Tracks, huts and reserves across the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges and the coast.

(<https://www.doc.govt.nz/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Hawke's Bay. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in **Moving to New Zealand**. When you'd like to talk it through, **we're here**, with no pressure and no pipeline.